10 Rainy-Day Activities That Actually Entertained My Toddler

October 9, 2026 · 3 min read

It rained for nine straight days last month. Nine. By day four my daughter was climbing the walls — literally, she tried to climb the hallway wall — and I was one more episode of the same cartoon away from losing it. So we tested everything. Here's what actually worked, ranked by how long it bought me.

1. Couch cushion fort. The undefeated champion. Every cushion off, blankets over the top, flashlight inside. She played in it for an hour and a half. An HOUR and a half.

2. Painter's tape roads. Tape roads all over the living room floor, cars driving between the "cities" (cushions). Forty minutes, and the tape came right off the wood.

3. Sink play. A step stool, the bathroom sink full of warm water, plastic cups and a turkey baster. She "washed" her toy animals for fifty minutes. I sat on the closed toilet and drank coffee. Bliss.

4. Sticker scenes. A roll of cheap dot stickers and big paper. She made what she called "a family" out of dots. Thirty-five minutes.

5. Laundry basket boat. Basket on a blanket, she sits in it, I drag her around the apartment while she yells "faster." Twenty-five minutes and my back hurt, but worth it.

6. Playdough with real kitchen tools. Garlic press, cookie cutters, a rolling pin. The garlic press was the star — she made "spaghetti" for twenty minutes straight.

7. Flashlight shadow puppets. Dark bedroom, flashlight, hands on the wall. She was more interested in the flashlight itself, but it still bought twenty minutes.

8. Sorting the spice jars. I know. But she loved lining them up by size and smelling each one. Fifteen quiet minutes. The cumin incident was survivable.

Now the flops, because honesty matters:

9. Baking together. Every blog says bake with your toddler. She ate raw flour, cried when I wouldn't let her crack the egg, and I finished the muffins alone while she watched cartoons. Never again until she's five.

10. The fancy craft kit. I bought a 20-euro "toddler art studio" box. She used it for six minutes, then asked for the cardboard box it came in. The box is now a garage for her toy cars. The kit is in a closet.

Honorable mention that didn't make the list because it's barely an activity: washing vegetables. I put her on the step stool at the kitchen sink with a colander of carrots and she washed each one like it was a tiny baby. Fifteen minutes of peace while I actually got dinner started. Sometimes the activity is just... letting them do the boring thing next to you.

The real lesson from nine days of rain: the best activities are the ones where the house already has the supplies and I don't have to perform. Water, tape, cushions, a flashlight. She doesn't need Pinterest. She needs me on the floor with her, slightly bored, fully there.